plans for a major departmental relocation in December. There is no dearth of space to house the offices temporarily. Three floors of the Visakhapatnam Metropolitan Development Authority headquarters at Siripuram are vacant. Another 30,000 sq. ft is ready for occupation at the Smart City building, besides vacant commercial spaces.

While the relocation will be an ordeal for government employees who shifted to Amaravati from Hyderabad just nine years ago, Jagan has announced timely incentives. The cabinet has approved the Guaranteed Pension Scheme, which fixes 50 per cent of the last pay as pension, a substantial increase over the current scheme's 20.3 per cent of basic salary. Additionally, the state will assist employees in acquiring housing sites before retirement and provide post-retirement health coverage for their families.

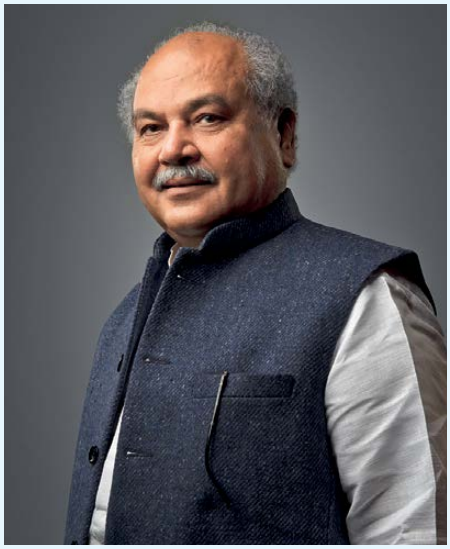


HIS BIG CAPITAL PLAN
Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy

ANI

Furthermore, the appointment of additional director general of police Ravi Shankar Ayyanar as the police commissioner aims to enhance security in the city. The Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation (GVMC) plans to introduce air-conditioned buses on the Bus Rapid Transit System routes, drawing inspiration from Srinagar's successful implementation of a similar system. "Srinagar has this and we are inspired to implement it here," says GVMC deputy mayor Jiyanni Sridhar. For the moment, Vizagites could not have asked for more. ■

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR





YASIR IQBAL

BATTLE FOR MADHYA PRADESH

BJP PULLS OUT THE BIG GUNS

By Rahul Noronha

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was in Bhopal on September 25 to address a grand gathering of Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) cadres, organised on the completion of its Jan Ashirwad Yatra. Even as the PM flew back the same evening, most within the state BJP had no inkling of the surprise the party's central command was about to spring on them later in the day. A second list of candidates for the Madhya Pradesh assembly election was announced that evening. It featured 39 names—among them seven Lok Sabha members, including three Union ministers. The following day, the BJP announced another candidate, taking the total to 79 and covering over a third of the 230 seats, even as the rival Congress is yet to come out with its first list.

It was on August 17 that the BJP announced its first list of 39 candidates in MP along with 21 in neighbouring Chhattisgarh. Early announcements of nominees and the fielding of senior leaders seem to be at the core of the BJP's strategy in both states (see *A Common Strategy*). For the BJP, which is

EARLY CANDIDATE ANNOUNCEMENTS, UNION MINISTERS AND MPs AMONG THOSE IN THE FRAY... THE BJP HAS LEFT NOTHING TO CHANCE